out], *hum chun chun ke hisaab lenge* [we will settle each and every account].'[164]

The second historical turning point was the rise of a Muslim party in Assam in 2005—All India United Democratic Front (AIUDF). It was founded by Badruddin Ajmal, the patriarch of a trading family that sold attar oil, perfumes and textiles, as a party of Muslim migrants who carried the 'Bangladeshi stigma'. Ajmal, who is also the president of the Assam branch of the Jamiat Ulema-e-Hind and is rated as among the 500 most influential Muslims in the world,[165] created the party within months of the Supreme Court scrapping the Illegal Migrants (Determination by Tribunal) Act of 1983.[166] Several observers in Assam trace the decline of the Congress in the state to the rise of Ajmal's party. As Assamese politics got divided along a Hindu–Muslim axis, AIUDF became the counterpoint to the BJP. The Congress was left in a virtual no-man's land in this politics of religious identities. On one end was the BJP, which warned of Assam going the 'Jinnah' way if Ajmal was voted in,[167] and on the other was Ajmal, who compared Assamese Muslims with Rohingya Muslims in Myanmar, arguing for 'all Muslims to come together'[168] because they were being 'treated like insects'.[169] From 2005 onwards, AIUDF began to split the Muslim vote, which earlier went only to the Congress in the one-third of Assam's districts that were Muslim-dominant. Tactical alliances between the Congress and AIUDF also drove away the sections of Assamese Hindus who were now opposed to Muslim migration. AIDUF won ten assembly seats (9.05 per cent votes) in Assam's 2006 assembly elections, eighteen (12.5 per cent votes) in 2011, thirteen (13.05 per cent votes) in 2016, and 16 (9.29 per cent votes) in 2021, making it a significant Opposition party. Muslim electoral assertion was a consequence of Hindu identity politics, but it also served as a fuel for further Hindu consolidation.

The Challenges of Expansion

While the BJP has metamorphosed into the largest national party in the Northeast, it also faces significant challenges. The anti-NRC